

In Texas, locating the missing becomes an unceasing task

At least 173 people are unaccounted for after catastrophic flooding

BY JOSHUA PARTLOW, BRADY DENNIS, TIM CRAIG AND MARIE-ROSE SHEINERMAN

CENTER POINT, TEXAS — Jaay Arredondo stood under the blazing Texas sun on Wednesday, taking in what little was left of Guadalupe Keys Resort, a once-tranquil RV park along the banks of the Guadalupe River. Nearby, chain saws hummed as volunteers slowly sliced through downed trees, trying to clear the way to the overturned trailers that sat mangled beneath the mountains of debris. “No telling what’s in there,” said Arredondo, 38, who owns an auto shop in San Antonio. He and his wife, Kristy, a disabled veteran, had spent years visiting this area with their three daughters and wanted to help the families who had lost people in any way they could. Like others, they had been shaken by just how many people remained missing in the wake of

the catastrophic floods here. As of Wednesday morning, there were at least 161 in Kerr County alone, and 173 in the region overall. “Unfathomable,” Arredondo said, echoing a sentiment felt up and down the banks of the river, where the searching carried on unceasingly almost a week after floodwaters roared through. For miles in every direction, the grim task unfolded once again Wednesday, as state and local authorities and bands of volunteers scoured the river. They moved on foot and horseback, in helicopters and in heavy machinery, overturning piles of debris by hand and peering into crumpled cars for any signs of those who had vanished. Even NASA acknowledged that it had joined the effort, saying in an email that it had deployed two conduct aircraft surveys to assist state and local authorities in ongoing operations. “We are just looking for bodies or parts,” said Lee Pool, 53, the chief of the Hunt Volunteer Fire Department. “Anything that can give these families closure.” One question looming was how so many people could remain missing amid the constant,

SEE FLOODS ON A7

Days after the river ran over, a father’s search is now for closure

BY ARELIS R. HERNÁNDEZ

INGRAM, TEXAS — It took two pieces of salvaged plywood to draw a crude map of the 10 miles of the Guadalupe River where volunteers should look for any signs of Aidan Heartfield. The 22-year-old called his father early on the Fourth of July saying he, his girlfriend and two friends awoke in the black of night to four inches of water pooled on the floor of his family cabin. A minute later, his dad recalled his son saying the water was up to four feet. They went outside seeking higher ground, but a tree soon slammed into the house, swiping the structure off its slab and leaving them without anything to hold on to. The phone went dead. Aidan and the others were missing. Three days later, Aidan’s dad, Thad Heartfield, stood over the map that denoted in black marker the boat ramps, bends and

bridges orienting the search party of more than 100 friends and strangers to a watery debris field between Waltonia Bridge and Schumacher Crossing. “This is an area of interest to us because it’s the hardest to search and it has produced some results,” Thad Heartfield said in a slow, steady voice as searchers encircled him. Results mean bodies. It’s a macabre specialty for the volunteers of Texas EquuSearch, a nonprofit search and recovery team that has worked on hundreds of cases for the sake of bringing families closure. Distinguished by their lemon-yellow shirts and Marlboro-smoking, joke-cracking, bent-backed leader, Tim Miller, the team holds fast to its operating principle that families of the lost should not search alone. They were called in specifically for the Heartfields.

SEE SEARCH ON A9

Red vs. blue: Trump pledges relief for Texas as California waits. **A7**

Camp Mystic: Facility had disaster plan, but questions remain. **A8**

NOAA: Nominee to lead agency says staffing is “a top priority.” **A8**



FROM TOP: Members of Texas EquuSearch search the Guadalupe River in Texas, on Monday. Lloyd Thornton, left, and Jason Boswell comb the riverbank. A cleanup crew clears debris.

Trump extends tariffs deadline

AUG. 1 IS NEW GOAL FOR TRADE DEALS

Reignites accusation ‘chickens out’ on policies

BY CAT ZAKRZEWSKI

After President Donald Trump paused his “Liberation Day” tariffs in April, his trade adviser Peter Navarro promised that the administration would deliver “90 deals in 90 days.” But that deadline came and went Wednesday with the White House 88 trade deals short. Trump has now given his administration 113 days to implement a worldwide tariff plan that he says will reverse decades of globalization and usher in a new era of domestic manufacturing. But CEOs, investors and foreign leaders appear skeptical that Trump will stick to that Aug. 1 deadline after watching him punt the issue again and again. The episode has reanimated the TACO debate — the Wall Street accusation that “Trump Always Chickens Out.” The term, coined by Financial Times columnist Robert Armstrong, describes a prevailing view in the financial sector that the president talks tough about tariffs and then ultimately backs down. Trump has made clear he doesn’t like the acronym. He falsely claimed that the deadline for tariff payments “has always been” Aug. 1 — after signing an executive order Monday that extended the deadline from July 9. “I didn’t make a change, a clarification, maybe?” Trump said during a wide-ranging Cabinet

SEE TRUMP ON A4

Brazil: Trump imposes 50% tariff over ex-president’s prosecution. **A5**

‘We are toast’: Feds brace for more layoffs after ruling

BY HANNAH NATANSON AND MERYL KORNFIELD

Some federal workers cried. Some shook their heads and began updating their résumés. Others — including union leaders — vowed to fight, determined to hang on to the government jobs that many took because they wanted to serve the American public. After the Supreme Court allowed President Donald Trump on Tuesday to resume firing government workers, federal employees rushed to Signal group chats and anxious phone calls, trying to figure out what it meant for them. The court lifted a lower-court order that had temporarily blocked the administration’s plans to lay off thousands of federal workers, including at the State Department and the Social Security Administration, because the administration did not first consult with Congress. But few details were immediately available. Litigation will continue as the layoffs proceed at 19 agencies, according to the ruling, which drew dissent from one liberal justice. It marks the latest upheaval in a chaotic half-year of Trump-driven downsizings of federal depart-

SEE WORKERS ON A4

Revelations about decades of adoption fraud in South Korea impel a dizzying quest for the truth

BY KELLY KASULIS CHO

For most of his life, Aaron Grzegorzczk believed that his birth name was Cho Yong-kee. He thought he was born on April 28, 1988, in a clinic in Anyang, South Korea, about 11 miles south of Seoul. He was told that his mother, a 19-year-old unwed woman, had abandoned him a day after giving birth to him. In an initial physical exam, he was recorded as “cute and alert.” Less than five months later, he arrived into the arms of his adoptive Polish American parents in Bay City, Michigan. He was their first child, sensitive and artistic, and his birth mother



A photo of Aaron Grzegorzczk, born Cho Yong-kee and adopted in Michigan. In some cases, the birth parents were lied to and told their child had died.

had surrendered him so that he could have, as his adoption papers put it, “an optimum future.” Grzegorzczk never questioned this story until this past March. That’s when his friend sent him an article detailing the South Korean government’s admission to five decades of adoption fraud. “I was reading it and I was just like, jaw open,” Grzegorzczk said. “I had absolutely no idea about any of this.” Immediately, he started digging into his past. South Korea’s adoption ‘industry’ Earlier this year, a South Korean government-appointed, inde-

SEE ADOPTION ON A13

Right-wing revolt in the West dooms GOP proposal to sell off public lands

BY KARIN BRULLIARD

To his surprise, Patrick Payne had ended up in a group text with Mike Lee. Payne is a conservative Idaho outdoorsman who voted for President Donald Trump. Lee is a Republican senator from Utah. The group was organized by an acquaintance Payne made online, and the topic was home schooling. But Payne saw an opportunity to directly challenge Lee on his proposal to sell up to 3.3 million acres of federal land in 11 Western states for the construction of affordable housing. He texted the senator that Washington was “better than BlackRock,” the glob-

al investment firm. Lee’s response — that he’d “trust anyone owning that land more than the U.S. government” — floored Payne. Several days later, he posted a screenshot of the exchange on X. “I thought it was important to let people know where he really stood,” said Payne, who spends much of his free time camping and hunting on federal backcountry in Idaho. That screenshot, posted by a self-described “regular citizen” with few online followers, racked up half a million views and became a flash point in a conservative revolt against Lee’s proposal, one powered by hunters but also prominent podcasters and

SEE LAND ON A6

IN THE NEWS

Call for more transparency Dozens of people who lost family members on the passenger jet involved in a midair collision over the Potomac want answers from the Army. **B13**

‘Certain death’ With fuel stocks dwindling amid an Israeli blockade, Gaza’s hospitals warn that they will need to halt services. **A11**

THE NATION The Supreme Court blocked Florida from enforcing a state immigration law. **A2**

The U.S. is suing California over its refusal to ban trans athletes in women’s sports. **A3**

THE WORLD Canadian military members were among four people arrested in an alleged plot to seize part of Quebec. **A12**

Some foreign students see new U.S. visa rules as “dystopian.” **A13**

THE REGION A D.C. man has been charged with murder in the long-unresolved stabbing of a woman found dead in 1999. **B13**

A private school in Virginia retaliated after parents said their daughter was a target of antisemitic bullying, a complaint alleges. **B13**

STYLE There’s plenty to love about “Too Much,” Lena Dunham’s new Netflix comedy that pays homage to rom-coms, Lili Loofbourow writes. **B1**

Followed by millions, the Dogist blog has helped turn canine photos into a social media phenomenon. **B1**

SPORTS The Nationals have been mired in a faltering rebuild. The Post took a hard look at the data to see how they got here. **B7**

LOCAL LIVING The cleaning aisle at any big box retailer has an arsenal of supplies, but five basic products are all you really need.

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